available with the company, in 2002, TISCO ‘signed an Automotive Steel Technology Cooperation Agreement’ with Nippon Steel Corporation of Japan and Arcelor of Europe to ‘work jointly on technical developments keeping the needs of the Indian automotive steel market in view’. Apart from this, new products were launched, export of cold-rolling products was taken up on priority and the company tied up with POSCO-Hyundai for processing cold-rolled coils and other products.

By 2002, the company had made vast strides. Encouraged, in May that year, Ratan rolled out a ‘Vision 2007’ document for the company. It rested on two pillars: the first was to strengthen the company to ‘seize the opportunities of tomorrow’ and make it ‘EVA [Economic Value Added] positive’; and the second, to ‘improve the quality of life’ of the employees of the company and the ‘communities’ it served.

The vision also encompassed six ‘Strategic Goals’, that the company should achieve. They included migrating from ‘commodities to Brands’, making the core business EVA-positive; ‘[continuing] to be [the] lowest cost producer of steel’; and building partnerships that would create value with ‘customers and suppliers’.

Ratan also announced his intention of ‘expanding capacity through acquisitions’. This was nothing new: it had its origins in his 1983 Strategic Plan. As he was planning bolder steps for the company, the aggressive implementation of his restructuring was evidently improving TISCO’s efficiency. In 2002, the company had scored 666 points in the JRD QV assessment matrix. In the following year, it bagged the next highest recognition, the JRD QV Sustained Excellence Award, for scoring over 600 points consistently for three years.

The company’s efficiency also gained international recognition. In 2003, TISCO became the only steel company in the world to win the MAKE (Most Admired Knowledge Enterprise) Asia Award, administered by Teleos, an independent knowledge management and intellectual capital research firm based in London. In the following year, TISCO was declared as ‘one of the lowest cost producers of steel in the world’.

As part of increasing its footprint abroad, it acquired the ‘steel business of Singapore’s NatSteel Ltd. for Rs 1,313 crore’; this was a company that was one-fourth the size of TISCO. It made the steel maker a ‘strong competitor to south-east Asian companies’ like Nippon and POSCO and also increased its capacity to 5.3 million tonnes. For the first time, the